


# Sentinels of the Dawn

Poor Clares of Perpetual Adoration
Our Lady of the Angels Monastery
Troyes, France

Spring 2015 Issue 18


## Unlocking Doors

*In the evening of that same day, the first day of the week, the doors were closed in the room where the disciples were, for fear of the Jews. Jesus came and stood among them. He said to them, "Peace be with you."* John 20:19

Easter is the celebration of Christ's Resurrection. And yet we, as members of Christ's body, are asked not to just celebrate it, but to live it. That is not always easy. Perhaps there are days when we prefer to just stay in bed, pull the covers over our head, and close out the world. Some days it might seem easier and safer to lock the doors of our house and avoid the circumstances and people of our lives. Some times we just want to run away, hide, and not deal with the reality of our lives.

Every time, however, we shut the doors of our life, our mind, or our heart we imprison ourselves. For every person, event, or idea we lock out, regardless of the reason, we lock ourselves in. That's what happened to Christ's disciples. It was Easter evening, the first day of the week, the day of the resurrection, the day they saw the empty tomb, the day Mary Magdalene announced, "I have seen the Lord." The disciples were gathered in the house, the doors were locked, due to their fear. A week later they were in the same place. It was the same room, the same walls, the same closed doors, the same locks. Nothing much had changed.



Jesus' tomb was open and empty but the disciples' house was closed and the doors locked tight. The house had become their tomb. Jesus was on the loose and the disciples were bound in fear. They had, in fact, separated themselves and their lives from the reality of Jesus' resurrection. Their doors of faith had been closed. They had shut their eyes to the reality that life was now different. They had locked out Mary Magdalene's words of faith, hope, and love. They left the empty tomb of Jesus and entered their own tombs of fear, doubt, and blindness. The locked doors had become the great stone sealing their tomb. They had locked themselves in. The doors of our tombs are always locked from the inside. All this, and it had been only one week.

After 40 days of Lent, after Easter Sunday, and as we journey through these 50 days of Easter, can we really say that our life is somehow different? Where are we living? In the freedom and joy of resurrection… or behind locked doors? How is our life different after Easter? And if it isn't, what are the locked doors of our life, our heart, our mind?

What are the closed places of our life? What keeps us in the tomb? Maybe, like the disciples, it is fear. Maybe it is questions, disbelief, or the conditions we place on our faith. Perhaps it is sorrow and loss. Maybe the wounds are so deep it does not seem worth the risk to step outside. For others it may be anger and resentment. Some seem unable or unwilling to open up to new ideas, possibilities, and change.

When we least expect it, He will break through the locked doors of the human heart. He will find us, in our fear and uncertainty. He understands our misgivings, our hurts, our infirmities and weaknesses. He knows only too well the human condition. And Jesus wants to give us another opportunity. That is part of the message of Easter. This is a time for seizing second chances. Jesus is always entering the locked places of our lives. He comes to give us His peace. Unexpected, uninvited, and sometimes even unwanted He steps into our closed lives, closed hearts, closed minds. Standing among us He offers peace and breathes new life into us. He doesn't open the door for us but He gives us all we need so that we might open our doors to a new life, a new creation, a new way of being.

Jesus gives us His peace, His breath, His life, and then sends us out. We are free to unlock the doors of our lives and step outside into His life. During this Easter season, let us invite Christ into our own locked upper rooms. Let us not be afraid to allow Him to break through any barrier that might be keeping Him out of our lives.

The Poor Clares of Perpetual Adoration wish you and your loved ones a most Blessed Easter Season... Christ is risen! Alleluia! Alleluia!

# "Waking up the World" during the Year of Consecrated Life

In his call for a year dedicated to Consecrated Life Pope Francis said it was his hope that religious sisters, brothers and priests would "wake up the world" with their testimony of faith, holiness and hope. What a challenge! One that he obviously feels can be obtained, by the grace of God. As cloistered, contemplative religious, we desire, both personally and as a Community, to respond to our Holy Father's challenge. It is one which causes certain aspirations to rise up within our hearts…

*What if…* the Year of Consecrated Life ushers in a new graced time for religious, a time of vitality, hope and vision, a twenty first century time, a time that addresses the cries of a twenty first century world? *What if…* we made a gesture of radical gratitude for the gift of religious life to the Church and to the world in a spirit of humility and openness? *What if…* we as religious, more than ever before, ignited hope, deepened our own sometimes fragile faith and gave prophetic witness to others of lives lived in solidarity with our brothers and sisters whom we encounter at the door, on the phone, crossing paths in the street? *What if…* our lives in Community were tangible signs of unity, of oneness and of connection, with each other, with all of God's creation? *What if...* we took seriously the words of Pope Francis: "…religious follow the Lord in a special way, in a prophetic way. It is this witness I expect of you. Religious should be men and women able to wake the world up, and show that they are a special breed who have something to say to the world today."

Pope Francis invites us during this year of Consecrated Life to revitalize ourselves from the "inside out". We are being challenged to demonstrate such a passion for life that we become instruments of the vibrancy of the Spirit for which we are all baptized, and for which we religious are consecrated. And so with this year well underway, the following are a few concrete ways in which our Community has begun to enter into its spirit.



On January 18th, we were delighted to spend the afternoon with one of the religious Communities of our diocese, the Sisters of Providence. Gathering together in our Parlor, we shared stories and strengthened our fraternal bonds. We closed the day by praying Vespers together and reciting the Holy Rosary in our Chapel. Our hearts were filled with joy and thanksgiving for the many blessings of this day and for the loving support and friendship of the Sisters of Providence. We cannot fail to mention here that their Community was the first to knock at our door upon our arrival in 2007, welcoming us with open hands and hearts!



Every Friday evening, we read a few pages from the writings of our Founders, Father Bonaventure and Mother Marie of Saint Clare. A few weeks after the visit with our Sisters of Providence, we were surprised to discover in the account of the death of our Foundress that our Sisters, overcome with grief at the death of their beloved Abbess, were ubable to sing her Requiem Mass. So the Sisters of Providence sang in their place! It is our hope that during this year we will make many other discoveries. It is our great desire to also translate the text of some of these documents preserved from the very beginning of the foundation of our Order, so as to be able to share this treasure of spiritual wealth with our other Monasteries throughout the world. How important and vital we feel this is for the future of our Order: a return to the source and origin of the spirit of our Founders in order to keep alive the flame of their charism and thus pass it on to future generations.



We are blessed to have Brother William, a Benedictine monk from the nearby village of Mesnil St Loup come to our Monastery for a monthly conference. At present he is helping us rediscover the beauty of *Vita Consecrata*, Pope John Paul II's apostolic exhoration on Religious Life. In January we were honored to welcome Father Eric de Clermont-Tonnerre, a Dominican from Paris. During his two-day visit to the Monastery, he gave us four conferences on Religious Life, drawing from the wealth of his pastoral experience as Novice Master, Provincial and Prior. He is scheduled to return to our Monastery again in June and October to give us two more series of conferences during this Year of Consecrated Life. We give thanks to God for the spiritual wealth that we are receiving through these two Brothers in Christ.



And so, we end with one final aspiration… at the conclusion of this special year on February 2, 2016, *what if* every religious community were to identify some ways it had answered Pope Francis' challenge? What a wonderful grace that would be for the Church and for the world!



## The floodgates of mercy are open

In his 2015 Message for Lent, our Holy Father wrote of the initiative *24 hours for the Lord*, which first began last year and his desire that it be observed again in 2015. "As individuals, we are tempted by indifference," he wrote. "Flooded with news reports and troubling images of human suffering, we often feel our complete inability to help. What can we do to avoid being caught up in this spiral of distress and powerlessness? First, we can pray in communion with the Church on earth and in heaven(....) Let us not underestimate the power of so many voices united in prayer! The *24 Hours for the Lord* initiative, which I hope will be observed on March 13-14 throughout the Church(...) is meant to be a sign of this need for prayer."

And so, on the second anniversary of his election as pontiff, where could Pope Francis be found? At St Peter's Basilica….leading a penitential celebration, hearing confessions and going to confession himself! At the same time throughout the world, hundreds of thousands of Catholics were united with him, as Churches were open, Eucharistic Adoration was made available, and priests were hearing confessions. The theme for this year's observance was "God Rich in Mercy" (Ephesians 2:4). It was with great joy that our Community participated in this event and spiritually united ourselves with our beloved Holy Father and Catholics throughout the world, as we observed the Holy Father's request, with the encouragement of our Bishop, Marc Stenger. During these two days, "non-stop" Adoration of the Most Blessed Sacrament was made available in our Chapel, with the Sisters assuring Adoration throughout the night. Other spiritual devotions were included in the daily program, including the Chaplet of Divine Mercy, the Litany of the Sacred Heart of Jesus, the Stations of the Cross. Most importantly, our Chaplain, Mgr. Bernard Savourat, was available in the Sacristy for a good portion of the afternoon of March 13th for those who desired to receive the Sacrament of Reconciliation. At the close of the *24 hours for the Lord*, our Chaplain presided at solemn Vespers and Benediction of the Most Blessed Sacrament.

Regarded by many as the "Pope of Mercy," our Holy Father offered another motive for the title with the surprise announcement on March 13th during the penitential celebration held at St. Peter's Basilica of an extraordinary Holy Year of Mercy, saying he wants "to make it evident that the Church's mission is as a witness of compassion." "Let us not forget that God forgives and God forgives always," Pope Francis said, repeating the words he used during his first Angelus as pope, on March 17, 2013. "Let us never tire of asking for forgiveness." Having already described his entire papacy as a "Kairos" of mercy, meaning a privileged moment in God's plan of salvation, Pope Francis said the time is ripe for that message. "I am convinced that the whole Church — which has much need to receive mercy, because we are sinners — will find in this jubilee the joy to rediscover and render fruitful the mercy of God, with which we are all called to give consolation to every man and woman of our time."

The Jubilee of Mercy will begin on December 8th, 2015, the Solemnity of the Immaculate Conception and will conclude on November 20th, 2016, Solemnity of Christ the King. The official and solemn announcement of the Holy Year will take place on Divine Mercy Sunday, April 12th. Traditionally, every 25 years the Pope proclaims a holy year, which features special celebrations and pilgrimages, strong calls for conversion and repentance, and the offer of special opportunities to experience God's grace through the sacraments, especially the Sacrament of Reconciliation.

## Good and faithful servant, enter into the joy of Your Master!



A priest of our diocese, a man of prayer, and a close friend of our community, Father Joseph Zirnhelt, passed from this life into Eternity on March 25, the evening of the solemnity of the Annunciation. It seemed only appropriate that he was called to his eternal reward on this great feast of Our Lord and His Most Holy Mother, since he was so devoted to them.

Since our arrival in Troyes in 2007, Father Zirnhelt rendered countless services to our Community. He was one of several priests who assured that the Holy Mass was daily celebrated in our Chapel until a Chaplain was assigned. Among the many wonderful memories we have of him, there are two that will be forever engraved in our hearts and minds: his presence as Master of Ceremonies for the Solemn Mass of the dedication of the altar of our renovated Chapel in 2011 and the conference he gave us with a mutual friend, Mrs. Nicole Hany-Longuespe, on the Treasures of the Cathedral of Troyes. He was also well acquainted with our older sisters, working for more than twenty years with our dear Sister Marie of the Trinity, former Archivist of our Monastery. Seeing the Sisters' poverty, he himself donated the necessary cartons to preserve our precious archive documents.

We give thanks to God before the Blessed Sacrament for the life of Father Zirnhelt, for his priestly ministry in our diocese, for his friendship. and for his goodness to our Community. We pray that God may bless him abundantly for his fidelity to his duties as Chancellor, Archivist of the Diocese, Canon, and Chaplain of the Oblate Sisters. May he hear the words, "*Well done, good and faithful servant, enter into the joy of your Master!*

# Bearing fruit a hundredfold

Perhaps you may remember that in one of the first issues of our newsletter, we featured an article on a pear tree that was offered to us by our Poor Clare Sisters in Bautzen, Germany. It was grafted from a tree that traces its "roots" back to Brixen, where a Monastery was founded by St. Clare of Assisi during her lifetime. It was planted in our cloistered garden and serves as a beautiful reminder of our fraternal union. A few weeks before the first day of spring, we were privileged to receive another "addition" to our garden: an apple tree which was grafted from one in the garden of the Abbey of Clairvaux and produces a variety of apples named "Magnificat". This year the Abbey of Clairvaux, the 3rd "daughter-house" of Citeaux, founded by St. Bernard (1090-1153), celebrates it's 9th centenary. We would like to thank Mr. Marc Petitprez for offering our Community this unique gift and for the many hours he generously spent pruning our other fruit trees. May the holy lives of Saint Clare and Saint Bernard inspire us to "grow and bear fruit", as we labor to build up God's Kingdom here below, singing each day in union with our Lady - *Magnificat !*




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# A new mission for St. Joseph the Worker

On March 19th, our Sisters who are great devotees of St. Joseph, went all out in celebrating his feast. All of his statues in the Chapel, Refectory and other parts of the Monastery were decorated with flowers and votive candles. And then there is the statue of St. Joseph in our cloister courtyard. He is not holding a lily, or the Child Jesus in his arms, but carpenter tools: he is ready for work! Even this statue was decorated, not with flowers and candles, but with a red shawl and surrounded by balloons, creatively transformed into imaginary birds with eyes and a beak. A line of bamboos sticks also served as a barrier. The reason behind this madness?! To scare off the pigeons who have lately been threatening to build their nest in the niche behind St. Joseph's statue! While we welcome every spring the swallows who seek shelter in our courtyard and build nests for their little ones, pigeons are another story! We salute our dear Sister Mary Antoinette who has spent much time and effort in researching how to prevent the pigeons from becoming permanent residents of our courtyard. A special thanks to Saint Joseph, too, for having a good sense of humor. One of the titles in his litany is terror of demons. Perhaps we could even add, "terror of pigeons"!

